

The Solar System

The Solar System consists of the Sun and the objects that orbit it, including eight planets, their moons, dwarf planets, asteroids, and comets. The Sun contains about 99.8% of the Solar System's total mass.

The Inner Planets

Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars are known as the inner or terrestrial planets. They are relatively small and have rocky surfaces. Earth is the only known planet to support life, largely due to liquid water and a stable atmosphere.

The Outer Planets

Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune are the outer or gas/ice giant planets. Jupiter is the largest planet in the Solar System, with a mass more than twice that of all other planets combined. Saturn is famous for its prominent ring system.

Moons and Exploration

Many planets have natural satellites called moons. Earth has one moon. Saturn has over 140 confirmed moons, the most of any planet. Missions such as Voyager 1 and 2, launched in 1977, have traveled beyond the Solar System into interstellar space.